

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Long-duration blackout

UTILITIES / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Plan around water, essential medical power, safe temperature, food and communications rather than a restoration estimate. Reserve battery power for necessities and use shelf-stable food when refrigeration fails. Keep all generators outdoors at least 20 feet from openings. Move early if essential care or safe shelter cannot be maintained.

Do now.

**List critical needs**

01

Identify power-dependent care, temperature-sensitive medicines, water access and who cannot manage stairs or heat. Set priorities before using scarce batteries or fuel.

**Measure what remains**

02

Write down safe water, ready-to-eat meals, usable batteries and medicine quantities. Review the inventory daily rather than guessing.

**Keep fuel use safe**

03

Never run generators, charcoal or camping stoves indoors, in a garage or on an enclosed balcony. Do not backfeed house wiring.

**Protect food and hygiene**

04

Keep cold appliances closed and use food-safety time and temperature guidance. Separate drinking water from washing and waste arrangements.

**Set a relocation trigger**

05

Choose the point when medical support, water or temperature can no longer be maintained. Confirm a reachable destination before those needs become urgent.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Build a daily plan from current supplies and reachable shelter options. Do not wait for a food distribution, public generator or rescue transport that has not been confirmed.

Watch for.

An announced restoration time is an estimate. Carbon monoxide, unsafe improvised wiring, dehydration and dangerous temperatures can be more urgent than the outage itself.

People & practical needs.

Plan shifts for checking vulnerable people and essential equipment so one caregiver is not awake continuously. Keep infant feeding, safe sleep, medicine storage and pet water on the same written daily inventory.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Share safe tasks and checked information with trusted neighbours. Charge essential devices when safe power is available and use brief scheduled check-ins. Do not rely on an internet-only plan.

Check the next usable option

Share safe tasks and checked information with trusted neighbours. Charge essential devices when safe power is available and use brief scheduled check-ins. Do not rely on an internet-only plan.

When the first option is unavailable

Build a daily plan from current supplies and reachable shelter options. Do not wait for a food distribution, public generator or rescue transport that has not been confirmed.

Questions in the field.

What runs out first?

List the current water, food, medicine and battery supply in usable quantities. Compare these with actual household consumption. Check the next refill or relocation option while reserves still exist; counting unopened items is not enough when they need power or water to use.

Which room should the household use?

Choose the safest available room for temperature and accessible movement. Do not use a garage, fuel-burning appliance or a vehicle in an enclosed area for warmth or charging. Keep the exit and sanitation route clear.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

CDC · Protect yourself during a power outage

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/response/what-to-do-protect-yourself-during-a-power-outage.html>

CDC · Avoid carbon monoxide poisoning

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/psa-toolkit/avoiding-carbon-monoxide-poisoning.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/long-blackout/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.